

I should probably give them all jobs so they can pay taxes...

A Great Divorce

Monika, Jessica, Sophia, Amelia, and Layla sat together at the table. Book club was a selective event, having only the best people. Bright sunny days like this regularly drew out the weekend warriors from their homes and placed them on the trails beside the great wooden cabin that stood on the outskirts of the suburbs. Today was the weekly gathering of book club for the group, which meant that the five would sit in a circle, sip wine, and talk about whatever was on their minds. Some days, they would even venture out to the patio, and witness the bird's flying to-and-fro, pondering rigorously the events of the past week. Other days, they would go into the miniature art-shed and look from the great windows to paint the glorious forest around them and the small pond behind their cabin. Finally, they would meet on Friday at noon to enjoy each other's company. This week, they decided to talk about the book *Fritz*. A great tale of fantasy, romance, and adventure brought everyone into a pleasant mood with debate. Even though only Layla had read the book, the rest commented drastically on whatever they thought was inside; basing what they said purely on the title or the synopsis on the back. The group's age averaged at 53. Each was married, but the talk of their husbands was strictly forbidden at book clubs. None of them had children.

Monika, the unspoken leader of the bunch in these meetings and owner of the cabin, started to pour wine 'round in order of favor. They sat in a particular order. Monika's futon was empty, which caused Jessica to desire to jump up and steal the glass-wall view from her. Jessica only had an armchair, a little less comfortable than the regular upholstered chairs Amelia and Layla had. She had a view in part, but Amelia was opposite of her blocking the full spectacle. Sophia had a similar position to Layla, opposite her. The star they sat in left Amelia and Layla most disadvantaged, as they saw the insides of the cabin losing the beautiful view of the outside world. Once the glasses are poured, Monika started off the meeting with the classic, "So, what do you think of *Fritz*? I particularly enjoyed when he fought for the love of Greta." Julia returned as well, following her statement, "me too. It was so cute". Now Monika had at least watched the movie; Julia had no clue what she was talking about. Fritz had been an absolute player in the novel, but in the movie, he was a more personable man. Monika had not known this; neither had the others, but Layla had read the book. A look of disgust at Monika had occurred, but no words were spoken from her mouth while the others agreed. The conversation very shortly after took a turn towards how much they disliked Nova, who was the blatant antagonist of

Greta often disrespecting her. Layla had not spoken for a while now, and instead simply sipped her wine faster than the rest.

As the evening mist fell on the cabin, the orange sky above told the group that it was time to depart while they continued their talk from the book to their outfits. Monika bore a simple red dress, which matched the gold jewelry that fell over her tan skin. The loafers she wore would quietly tap against the ground when she would move to pour the wine. Jessica had a bold baby-blue dress which shaped her body perfectly. The lightless emerald earrings she had argued with her red hair, although nobody would point this out in fear of her blue eyes piercing into their soul. Sophia was quite average, wearing a slightly oversized navy-blue dress over her small figure. Amelia had put her all into her outfit, which matched Monika's in almost all regards except for the missing jewelry. Her red dress had been desaturated with age, and there were two large wine stains on the outsole of her white shoes. Nobody noticed anything bad of course, since she played the dress off as pink and the shoes as red bottomed. Layla had usually been the largest of the bunch in height and girth. It was not that she was fat; none of them were, but it was natural to be larger in size when taller than the rest. She wore a spotted emerald dress with emerald earrings to match. A gorgeous green beret sat over her straight black hair and drew attention to her green eyes, a perfectly matching outfit. Each had their own respective style, beautiful at least, but each had the same formal standard. Amelia decided to speak above her superiors and back-handedly complemented Layla's single oddity, speaking pugnaciously, "I really like how you added a beret to your outfit and how thin your waist is compared to normal. How did you do it?". Layla was quite flustered; she had barely spoken over the past few hours and was not expecting an offence at her figure, which had never come in the past few weeks when they started meeting. "I'm impressed anyone had noticed," she said with a slight irony, "I started wearing a modern corset, it's surprisingly comfortable." This moved the group, as one-by-one they came to the same conclusion. Monika picked up on this and had to stabilize the rest of the group. In the next few moments, something great happened. Layla was expelled from the following book clubs due to her lack of contribution.

The days flew by, and abruptly it was Friday again. A soft rain fell under black cloudy skies, mourning the loss of the previous member, but the group were happy as ever. Four was an ugly number, so Monika had been tasked to bring in another member. With that, Aalia was brought with jubilation. The rest still dressed in similar outfits, but Aalia wore a hijab over her modest attire. One of the irrelevant differences between Monika, Jessica, Sophia, and Amelia was that they appeared slightly skinnier, as if someone snatched their waists. This week there was a little more drinking and a little less talk due to the gloomy mood of the dark skies. They had agreed to, seriously, read a short fiction book named

Maria. This played like many other books have. Maria, the high-powered owner of "The Sweet Spot," tried to focus on her ski trip, but couldn't stop calling her husband, Jeffery, who was hopelessly failing at managing the bakery back home. Up on the pristine slopes of Argentina, she met Ernesto, her ruggedly charming ski guide. Ernesto quickly noticed Maria's trouble. He challenged her to forget her home and enjoy the mountain, insisting that she needed to truly *breathe*. Maria initially resisted his rustic charm, determined to return to her orderly life, but the breathtaking beauty of the Andes, and Ernesto's captivating smile, made her second-guess about everything and leave permanently to Argentina. The whole group enjoyed the book and had various opinions on its contents. Unlike Layla, Aalia was more talkative and controversial. The rest of the group had agreed with her since she was a newcomer.

Monika was the only one bold enough to say, "I thought it was beautiful how she left her old life to live again happily." Still, Aalia returned, "Yes, but it was not kind or justified to leave Jeffery." This earned her a lot of respect within the rest of the posse. As they got up to leave, a sharp, high-pitched clipping emanated from the wooden floors. Nobody had noticed this previously of the hubbub that arose during the late arrival of Amelia, but she had a new pair of glossy black high heels. This time, Sophia commented on her outfit, "When did you get those," she said with a superficial grin. These were much more formal and proper than loafers and had no place in the clearly informal book club, "They make you look so tall and elongated." Amelia had quieted down since the removal of Layla. Her already thin and tall appearance extended with the addition of standing on her toes, giving her a new arrogance. Although she was uncomfortable standing there for such time conversing about how good she looked, she had smiled throughout. Monika was embarrassed she had not thought of adding these to her outfit. She always found them impossible to wear from a sharp angle her feet would bend to accommodate beauty. She had regularly been the tallest of the group naturally, but the extra 4 inches added to Amelia's height made her noticeably shorter now. Everyone in the group liked Monika more than Amelia, so she was gone.

In the upcoming Friday, a new member was added. As the newest newcomer, Aalia was given this role. She chose her close friend Fatima who conversed best with Aalia but was engaging enough with the rest of the group. This Friday, the lack of storms and cloudless blue skies caused the group to move to the art-shed. Since Monika had contributed the supplies, they were to have a simple contest. Whoever was able to paint the pond and surrounding forest the best would take home a cheap bottle of wine in trade for the painting. Since Monika had gone to college as a fine arts major, she had the upper hand over the rest. She was convinced her bottle of wine would stay her bottle of wine. Upon exiting the cabin, a cool brisk breeze reflected the fall temperatures, leaves coated

with the concrete path and lined everything underfoot only betraying this for the common pine. A familiar, sharp, high-pitched clip originated through the leaves and flowed from underneath the coat of leaves. After the brisk walk, each set out to their respective windows, side by side as if in a queue somewhere. Each of the original three removed the leaves from the spikes of their heels, then entered in; with Aalia and Fatima chattering in the back.

The paintings were made and judged between them all causing more internal conflict. Although they drew the curtains between the five rooms Monika had made built, it seemed that once voting began Aalia and Fatima thought as one, while the rest of the group thought as a separate body. The vote was close, three to two in Monika's favor. The top two was drastically different, being Monika and Fatima's paintings. Monika's was entirely objective, showing each remaining leaf on the tree; each on the ground; colors matched the sky almost directly. Reflections of the clear ripple less pond depicted the nimble clouds in the distant skies and the empty branches of brown trees. The cabin snuck sneakily behind the slow, wandering concrete path that brought them here. She did have the best view being furthest right, but that did not entirely bring the tie so close. Fatima's was more ludicrous; being very similar to Monika's in some regards, but each detail was a little twisted. The colors were slightly saturated with a red hue, leaves stayed on the trees and the water was full of motion. But it was not the actual paintings that caused this decision; that was unimportant; it was the status and friendship between them. Yet after this vote, Monika still opened the bottle for the entire group back in the cabin. The day moved on, the wine bottle emptied, and the conversation dried with their livers. Sophia was talkative as normal, but there was a palpable distaste for Fatima and Aalia whenever she spoke in return to them.

On exit, Sophia stayed behind to have a conversation with Monika in concern of the two newcomers. Idle chat continued late into the evening as the sun set, and both became more inebriated. The cabin started to chill, but they stayed, nonetheless. The conversation took a sobering turn, as Sophia started to persecute, "seriously though, we need to keep members in our group who will support us. I'm not going to say names, but it seems that we have subgroups forming which have different ideas that don't like to get together that much." Monika interrupted, "what are you getting at Sophia, I don't understand why you're scared of the newest members." Sophia was not entirely certain as to why as well. There was no reason to fear them based on their actions or differences of thought; everyone got along even though there wasn't full agreement. "I just don't understand why we're ousting so many people just to bring in anyone off the street. Especially since we have different morals and tolerances," she concluded. "Hey, I vetted Aalia just fine! Maybe you're just

intolerant, we don't need you around here anymore." Monika took Sophia's thoughts into consideration and vetted the next member as well as possible.

Upon consensus from the rest of the population, Isabella was the newest member. She had been a distant friend from college that went into a major in social activism, a great fit for this demographic. Luckily, she somehow knew everyone at the book club already. Sophia's replacement was set to come in this Friday at noon! Monika didn't need to give a reason to her loyalist member, Jessica. The rest approved of this since they did not like the tone she spoke to them. Surprisingly, Isabella had converted to Islam after college. This brought her to find solace with Aalia and Fatima over Jessica and Monika. This brought a new dynamic to the structure of these meetings. On this day, they all sat in the five great Adirondack chairs which sat on the porch of the cabin. The wine was poured, this time by Isabella, being the closest mediator. Talk began and continued, "Birds are so cool," Monika said, bringing cause to agreement with the entire group. Then, Monika started to ask for some advice, "My husband has been bleak lately. He keeps listing the things he does—the groceries, the yard, the laundry, how exhausting his job was—as if crossing items off a to-do list equals a happy marriage. I hear him say, 'I'm trying my best,' but it just feels like he's doing the bare minimum of basic adulthood, not trying his best to connect with me. He handles logistics, sure, but I'm the one who carries weight. I manage the anxiety, the atmosphere, our emotional state, including his! I'm constantly having to prompt him, thank him, and then deal with his resentment when his 'big effort' doesn't suddenly fix everything. It's exhausting. I feel totally stuck. We've gone nowhere in years. I need effort that moves us forward, not just maintenance that keeps us exactly where we are. I'm simply unhappy in this marriage, I want to feel equal and I don't know what to do."

Jessica showed Monika little empathy nor remorse. She was more intoxicated than usual since the wine emptied as fast while being divided by just her and Monika. She decided to partially scorn her, "When I hear 'I'm stuck,' what I'm really hearing is 'I'm waiting for him to make me happy.' That's a fundamentally selfish way to approach marriage. You are draining him by constantly moving the goalposts and devaluing his contributions. If you feel unfulfilled, that's your problem to solve, not his. Stop obsessing over what he's not doing and start looking at what you are contributing to the stagnation. Maybe if you started appreciating the effort he is putting in, instead of putting values to how much each of you contribute. Right now, you're just pushing him away with negativity. Also, I thought that talking of husbands is not allowed at book clubs." Isabella had a problem with this response. She very much did not support any of Sophia's points. Although it went against some of her religious teachings, those did not apply to Monika yet, so she started to argue, "Wow, that is incredibly cold and unhelpful. You are completely missing the point! She's not being 'selfish'; she's asking to be loved and seen as a whole person, not

just a manager who delegates tasks. You sound like you're defending his laziness. You clearly don't understand the invisible weight she carries. It's easy to judge when you're not the one doing heavy lifting in your marriage. Her dissatisfaction isn't about her lack of appreciation; it's about his lack of genuine, heartfelt connection. You should be supporting her, not making excuses for someone who has emotionally checked out of his marriage." Monika considered both arguments and concluded her insights.

Jessica had never really been loyal. The rest of the group were good at their support. But with her removal, the mood had changed at the book club. Meetings became more religious, and Monika had less control over the events past setting up the time to unlock the cabin to the other three. But adding more people became tiresome, and it was best to have those who agreed with one purpose. But Monika was the one that disagreed with the majority now, and she couldn't kick herself out of the group; that would be redundant. At least it was nice to wear a more casual dress. She took off the uncomfortable high-heels and corset, wore less make-up and let her hair down. The months passed and clubs went on; Monika went through with her divorce under the advice of Isabella. Monika had adhered to the rest of the group and started to practice their culture. She now also wore a hijab, which was very nice in the winter. Her attempt to file abandonment had worked in her favor as the judge was empathetic to her situation. She inherited the cabin and shed, along with her three cats and enough money to keep her comfortable until her late nineties. But that was forty years away; she didn't need to think about that yet. Now, she was looking for ways to be happy, book club was a simple delicacy, but she wanted more.

The same wine bottle had sat in the same position since Jessica's leave. Monika again broke the rule after the past three club meetings and directly prompted, "you know, I don't know if any of you have a husband. In fact, I've never asked if you had children or any animals." Fatima spoke for Aalia, "one of the reasons we wanted to bring in Isabella is because me and Aalia are married to the same man. We each have two children, a total of two girls and two boys, who make us very happy. Muhamed is quite the man; he can provide us with anything we need." This brought great interest to Monika... she was available. Any man that could provide for two wives certainly could make a third happy. Aalia continued, "Even though we are happy, he's never around. Always on those business trips down to Nigeria. But when he is back home it's like we're not enough." Aaila finished, "I know he's doing something with our distant  arrah Aisha there; she's only nine. I'm surprised he hasn't been gifted more wives or workers from his status there." Monika asked, "While I respect your positions, I have recently fallen out of love and could use someone to help me be happy, I would be honored to be your  arrah as well as sister in faith." While Isabella witnessed all this, she was quite disgusted. As she was married too, but did not have to share him with anyone. She spoke, "I'm married to Juanito; he doesn't

need to share with anyone. Although I realize Allah allows for multiple wives, we both do not think it would be just to allow him more, since I try my hardest to make him happy.” But Monica did not care for this, she was very interested in Muhammed. As snow gradually froze the ground, the group departed. Monika had one thing in mind.

Days passed like raindrops as the clock spun wildly. Monika had gotten her wish to meet Muhammed, and it went better than expected. She was now wed to him. He had told her his tale of how he came to be such a businessman. He had met with Gabriel, a businessman from Britain. With just three handshakes, he now owned a banana plant, coffee plant, and some sort of transportation service. From all, he profited immensely. But Monika really didn't care about how much money he made; she only cared about him. Although he was noticeably illiterate, his body looks made up for this. And her wedding night was amazing. Muhammed had dictated this to be the last meeting at Monika's cabin, and she had agreed to this since she did not enjoy the cold of winter. She would rather live with Muhammed and Aisha in Nicaragua in the winter seasons. And it was so. The rest of them who lived in America were made to meet in each other's homes instead of the cabin. Monika was set to fly out in the morning. Her last night in the cabin was lonesome. She had asked Muhammed to demolish it and get rid of the bad memories of her past life it held. But still she felt some remorse for this old building. Maybe it would have been best to have made other decisions, but it was too late for that now. She found what she wanted and desired. And she lived happily ever after, or at least until she woke up one morning and realized her home was made of iron.